activity strengthens skills, capabilities and employment at home. And that, in turn, constantly updates and tests our mettle. In many ways, foreign policy is an exercise in competitiveness and its economic facets a reflection in a particular domain.

In the last few years, India achieved ambitious export goals that would have been considered unrealistic till just recently. Now, this is not just a substantial increase in aspiration but one realized as the world economy is still recovering from the Covid pandemic. The basis for this confidence is a range of reforms in manufacturing, labour, finance, skills and trade facilitation. Added to that is a steady improvement in the ease of doing business. Foreign commercial policy is being tasked to obtain access to markets and lower trade barriers. This can be done in an orthodox way but hastened through negotiated understandings, including free-trade agreements (FTAs) and global supply chains. That may be an objective in itself; its larger significance for employment and prosperity are obvious.

Increasingly, foreign policy contributes to the creation of new capacities at home. In Asia, all modernizing economies have single-mindedly focussed their external interactions on obtaining capital, technology and best practices from abroad. Japan was the pioneer in this regard during the Meiji era, and China, after Deng Xiaoping, was the most successful in terms of scale. In the last few years, India, too, has embraced this mindset. We have notable examples of benefits to people from endeavours at the enterprise level or in national projects. It may be information technology (IT) or auto manufacturing, food production or food processing, metros or bullet train, space capabilities or nuclear energy: the fruits of foreign collaboration are there for all to see.

Newer challenges like green growth and climate action have started to open up more possibilities. Our partners have expanded from the older industrialized economies to more innovative ones. All this happens because of our ability to identify, engage, negotiate and leverage opportunities of interest abroad across many domains. The most effective foreign policy is the one that focusses and delivers on development.

The resources and opportunities provided by external collaborations speed up the natural growth of the domestic economy. Valuable as they are, they do not, however, substitute the continuous nurturing of deep strengths at home. As we have discovered through experience, confusion on that score can have damaging consequences.